

The unsocial internet of things

Unsocial networking

Siddharth found out, for his column, that the number of internet connected devices surpassed our global population years ago, and of course went unnoticed. When discussing that fact, all of us felt it as totally logical. Of course we have more devices than people, because the amount of devices one connected individual uses is a lot more than one.

Let's take my own home as an example to calculate the amount of net-connected devices I have: A laptop (no wait two laptops, but one of them we rarely use), three phones, an iPad, iPod touch, Nexus 7, Wii, PS3, two routers, a net-connected baby monitor, a NAS drive, Tata Sky+ box, a net-connected amplifier... that's at least 16 devices shared between a couple and a baby. We also have devices that exist to connect us at work as well, though usually just a PC or laptop...

The fact that most of these can talk to each other over the net or my routers makes the Internet of things seem almost obvious. In fact if I ever succumb to the temptations to buy even more gadgets – smart TVs and refrigerators that tweet when I'm low on milk, etc., this number will only go up. And I'm not even counting my son's tech-enabled toys that will no doubt be added to the mix in the future.

So will the internet of things soon just be the internet of everything; sort of like it is in the upcoming game Watch Dogs?

Probably not.

Just as you don't have too many people on your friend list whose Facebook profile is filled out in Mandarin, or German, etc., assuming that all devices will just be able to talk to one another is a little far fetched right now. And we're not going to fix that anytime soon unless we just run absolutely everything on a single platform – as they've described in Watch Dogs as CTOS (CenTral OS).

Let's assume we live in utopia where all the "big guys" would cease to care about their stockholders for long enough to give a damn about the rest of the world, and come together to (gasp) share information and build devices based on pre-decided standards. Basically, we'd have a conglomerate called MegaCorp (or something less Hollywood-ish) that sold us everything tech-based. Even then, there will always be people like me who don't throw away

their perfectly working router just because it's not 802.11n, and keep both N and G networks running in the house. Backwards compatibility is desirable, after all.

The laptop I don't use... it runs Windows XP, which isn't supported anymore. I only use it sparingly, and have actually turned it on and let my son bang away at the keyboard as he imitates me writing an article... Fact is, it's a legacy device, connecting to the Internet, talking to other devices, and is a security hole.

I have no doubt that we are far from being able to write perfect software that has no security holes. Hackers will forever test and retest our code to try and find flaws, and we will forever be patching the holes they discover. It's also obvious that older code that's not being supported will have more holes potentially. Though it might even out as less hackers will be focussing on dead software, and more interested in newer, more popular code to exploit. Still, if you come back to the example of my house, I suppose the weak link is the laptop with XP, or maybe the older D-Link router that I haven't bothered to firmware upgrade for ages, or the PS3, or maybe even the Denon AMP that's so niche that I probably wouldn't even know if there was an exploit available for it.

This is the chink in the armour of the internet of everything. We may be willing to upgrade our phones every two years, or even sooner, but we will not allow that for other devices. Would you rather upgrade your router just because it cannot offer some new but unnecessary feature, or keep it because it still works perfectly?

Apart from a few product categories, we've reached a point where we're content for a lot longer with what we have. This means more legacy devices and as a result, which may equal a less secure internet of things, but more importantly, means an ever increasing list of devices that can talk to a few others but not every other device. Not exactly the most social of networks...



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